aware we could be batting together in a Test for the last time. I remember feeling mixed emotions as I took guard, sad because an era was ending, yet happy because I had enjoyed so many opportunities to play alongside a cricketer I so admired and a person I liked so much.

The statistics show that we batted together 44 times in Test matches, adding a total of 3 108 runs with an average of 75.80 runs per partnership. We shared in 13 stands of more than a hundred between 2004 and 2013, suggesting there was roughly a one-in-three chance of us sharing a century stand when we batted together.

Among all the pairs of batsmen in Test history who batted together more than 40 times, only three claim a higher average number of runs per partnership: Justin Langer and Ricky Ponting of Australia, Jack Hobbs and Herbert Sutcliffe of England, and Mohammad Yousuf and Younus Khan of Pakistan.

In Durban, I was pleased to be standing at the non-striker's end when Jacques followed the fairytale script and reached his 45th and last Test century playing his 166th and last Test. Our partnership was worth 127 runs when I was out for 74, but Jacques continued and we reached a total of exactly 500 all out.

Dale did the rest: he had taken six wickets in the Indian first innings, and proceeded to claim the crucial wickets of Pujara and Kohli in one devastating spell of world-class fast bowling. The tourists were bowled out for 223, and our openers knocked off the 58 runs required for victory without a problem.

At the end of another successful year, we were on top of the world, statistically speaking, standing at No. 1 in both the ICC Test rankings and the ICC ODI rankings. As a Test team, remarkably, the records show we had only lost one of the previous 25 series, a run of success that stretched back to 2006.